

Writing your main point on the slide as well as saying it

8 findings · 12-step checklist · 1 myth · 7 sources · cheatgrid.com

Writing the line you're about to say onto the slide feels like backup, partly for the room, partly so you don't go blank. Reading it while you say it **makes the point harder to follow**, not easier.

THE GOAL

You're trying to make the room keep your point, not just prove you said it. Let any slide text anchor only **the one detail** you most want them to remember.

CHECKLIST

You've just typed out, word for word, the line you're about to say, and you're deciding what happens to it on the slide.

- ☐ Read back the sentence you just wrote for yourself, and pick the one detail in it you most need the room to keep.
- ☐ Delete that full sentence from the slide, and keep the complete wording only somewhere you alone will see while you talk.
- ☐ Check whether this slide has an image, chart, or diagram the detail is about.
- ☐ If it does, pick **two or three words** naming the image part the detail is about, and place them touching it.
- ☐ If it doesn't, leave the slide with no added text, and say the detail out loud only.
- ☐ Swap any generic title like "Overview" for the specific detail it's about.
- ☐ If you're keeping more than one point on this slide, set them to appear one at a time, each as you start talking about it.
- ☐ Say the full sentence out loud once while looking only at what's now on the slide, and cut any word your voice already carries.
- ☐ If this room already knows the subject well, **cut the on-screen words back further** than you otherwise would.
- ☐ If your accent or the room's noise could make you hard to catch, keep fuller wording on screen instead of a short caption.
- ☐ Cut anything still on the slide that you kept "just in case" someone missed a word.
- ☐ Move on to the next slide only once this one carries no more than the words you deliberately decided to keep.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** Letting the room read your point instead of explaining it **costs you their understanding**. Hearing something explained while looking at the image beats reading the identical words off the screen, and that held up in dozens of separate studies.
- 2** The evidence that hearing beats reading isn't about people working through material at their own pace. It held up most strongly when the presentation itself set the pace, which describes a live talk exactly.
- 3** If your room already knows the subject, keeping your point in writing on screen **costs them, not helps them**.

What repeating your point in writing costs you

DON'T

Don't put the sentence you're about to say into words on the slide too. It makes things worse.

Seeing and hearing the identical words at once competes with the point: two experiments found fewer solved problems with the text added than without it. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Letting the room read your point instead of explaining it **costs you their understanding**. Hearing something explained while looking at the image beats reading the identical words off the screen, and that held up in dozens of separate studies.

The advantage of hearing over reading was largest for complicated material with several moving parts to track, which is what a live talk usually is. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

The evidence that hearing beats reading isn't about people working through material at their own pace. It held up most strongly when the presentation itself set the pace, which describes a live talk exactly.

In a live room you can't pause or rewind the presenter, so the hearing-over-reading advantage applies more, not less, to your actual talk. [Source 2](#)

What to put up there instead

DON'T

Don't strip every word off the slide, even though the full sentence doesn't belong there.

Placing a couple of words right against the matching part of the image raised how well people remembered it later, though not what they understood. [Source 3](#)

DO

Write any slide label as the actual point instead of a topic tag. Students who saw the exact detail as the slide's heading recalled it afterward more often than students who only saw a vague phrase there.

The heading told students exactly **what to file the detail under**, which stuck better than the same detail buried in a bullet list. [Source 4](#)

DO

Reveal any kept words one at a time, as you reach each one. People who watched points appear in step with the talk scored better and learned more efficiently than people who saw it all at once.

Showing everything at once forces people to hold your whole sentence in mind while hunting for the part you're currently discussing. [Source 5](#)

What changes with who's in the room

KNOW

If your room already knows the subject, keeping your point in writing on screen **costs them, not helps them**.

The same extra explanation that helps a newcomer follow along works against someone who already understands it: experienced trainees did worse with it, not better. [Source 6](#)

DO

Keep more on-screen text when the room might struggle to catch your actual words.

Full text helped people catch a hard-to-follow voice better on a later test, though it still didn't help them use what they'd learned. [Source 7](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

People take in information differently, some by seeing and some by hearing, so writing your point on the slide as well as saying it lets everyone learn it their own way.

ACTUALLY

Splitting people into readers and listeners isn't what happens when you add matching text to speech. In a direct test, **the whole group did worse**, not just some readers doing better while others stayed the same. [Source 1](#)

Sources

1. <https://www.sfu.ca/~jcnesbit/EDUC220/ThinkPaper/MayerMoreno2002.pdf>
2. <https://eric.ed.gov/?id=EJ723937>
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Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Giving a presentation at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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